

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

SHAHI IDGAH | *Mathura*

THE ROW

The issue traces back to a 1964 lawsuit filed by the Shri Krishna Janmasthan Sewa Sansthan over ownership of the entire 13.37-acre land believed to be part of Lord Krishna's birthplace. It is also here that Shahi Idgah mosque stands over 2.5 acres, which Hindu groups claim was built after razing the Keshavadeva temple on Aurangzeb's orders in 1670. In 1968, the two groups had reached a compromise.

THE PETITIONERS

Fresh petitions emerged in 2020 when Lucknow-based lawyer Ranjana Agnihotri and six others, representing 'Bhagwan Shri Krishna Virajman', sought the mosque's removal. Their initial plea was rejected, but a revision petition was accepted in May 2022. To date, over 15 cases have been filed, all seeking the mosque's removal.

CURRENT STATUS

In December 2023, the Allahabad HC ruled that the case was not subject to the Places of Worship Act, 1991, which preserves the religious character of sites as they stood in 1947, and permitted a court-monitored survey of the mosque. The SC stayed this order in Jan. 2024. The case will now be heard on April 1.

AJMER SHARIF | *Ajmer*

THE ROW

A legal battle has sprung up over Khwaja Moinuddin Chishti's dargah in Ajmer, Rajasthan, with claims that the revered 13th-century Sufi shrine, which attracts multi-faith devotees including political leaders and celebrities, was originally a Shiva temple.

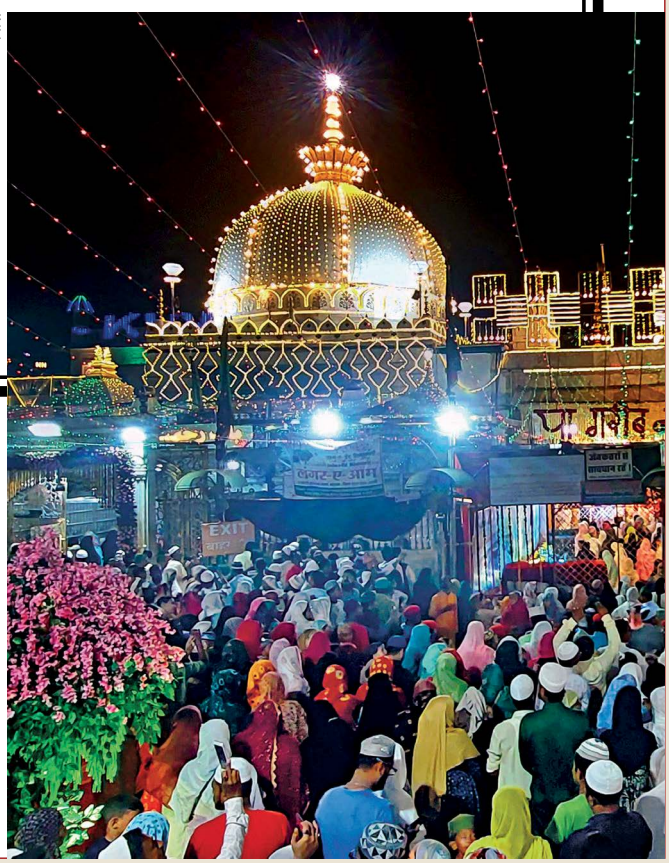
THE PETITIONERS

This claim was brought alive again in the immediate aftermath of the communal tensions that erupted in Sambhal in Nov. 2024. A lawsuit filed by Vishnu Gupta, national president of the Hindu Sena, a right-wing Hindu nationalist organisation founded in 2011, questioned whether the dargah is protected under the Places of Worship Act, besides seeking to reclaim the site for Hindu worship.

CURRENT STATUS

Muslim leaders like AIMIM chief Asaduddin Owaisi view the lawsuit as an attack on India's pluralistic traditions. The BJP's state unit chief, Madan Rathore, calls such litigations a fallout of the "Congress's appeasement policy" while claiming they will respect the court's decision. A local court has received replies from the Dargah Committee, ASI and other respondents and has listed the matter for hearing on April 19.

ANI



mindsets, pride in India's heritage and roots, strengthening unity and a sense of duty among citizens. "Muslims or Islam are not our enemy," says a top RSS leader. "The symbols of colonialism, created only to demoralise the Hindu community, shouldn't be glorified. To build pride in our roots and do away with the colonial mindset, there is a need to tell the stories of our heroes to the future generation."

The problem with the Hindutva project, as historian Purushottam Agrawal (see column, *Why are We Digging Graves of the Past?*) sees it, is that it is not bound by authenticity